

**ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026**

# Nonprofit and NGO English

## Conversation lab

Use these role cards to practice a response, handle a follow-up, and repeat with a new communication challenge.

**PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK**

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

# How to use the conversation lab

1. Read the shared case. Spend two minutes noting the facts and your first response.
2. Assign roles. The responding professional uses role A; the listener uses role B. Read your own role privately before you begin.
3. Speak for 45-60 seconds. The listener asks a follow-up instead of simply agreeing. Continue until the meaning and next action are clear.
4. Reveal the model response. Identify one useful expression and compare it with your own wording.
5. Switch roles. Use the second-round challenge and speak again with fewer notes.

## If you are studying alone

Speak both roles aloud. Leave a pause after the question, then answer without looking at the model. You can also write a four-turn exchange and read it back for clarity.

## Useful conversation repair

- Could you say that another way?
- When you say that, which part do you mean?
- Let me check that I understood correctly.
- I need a moment to separate what is confirmed from what is still unknown.

## Feedback

Judge whether the listener understands the situation and can identify the next action or unresolved question. Correct one meaning issue and one useful language pattern, then repeat.

## CONVERSATION 01

# Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

**SHARED CASE**

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

**Useful expressions**

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

**Second round**

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 02

# Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

**SHARED CASE**

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

**Useful expressions**

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

**Second round**

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 03

# Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

**SHARED CASE**

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

**Useful expressions**

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

**Second round**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 04

# Field Operations and Partner Coordination

**SHARED CASE**

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

**Useful expressions**

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

**Second round**

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 05

# Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

**SHARED CASE**

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

**Useful expressions**

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

**Second round**

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 06

# Volunteer Management and Training

**SHARED CASE**

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

**Useful expressions**

In [specific situation], I noticed ... .

The effect was ... . What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

**Second round**

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 07

# Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

**SHARED CASE**

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

**Useful expressions**

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

**Second round**

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

## CONVERSATION 08

# Board Reporting and Sustainability

**SHARED CASE**

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

**Role A | Responding professional**

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

**Role B | Listener**

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

**Useful expressions**

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

**Cover this until after your first attempt**

The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

**Second round**

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

**Debrief**

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

# Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

## Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

## Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

## Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

## Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

## Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

## Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

## Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

# Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

## Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

## Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

### Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

### Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

## Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.